Kwan's Crusade

Champion skater Michelle Kwan shares her story in the name of the United States.

Michelle Kwan has a new pair of shoes to fill—and they aren't ice skates. Beginning this year, the figure-skating champion will travel around the globe, visiting schools to speak to young people about the values of the United States.

Kwan, 26, in November [2006] accepted the new challenge to help improve the nation's image **abroad**[1]. That is when U.S. Secretary of State Condoleezza Rice appointed her the first American public **diplomat.** A diplomat is a person who represents his or her country abroad.

According to Rice, many children in other countries are exposed to negative messages about the United States. As an **envoy,** or messenger, Kwan will share her own life experiences and successes. "Like so many Americans, Michelle Kwan has a unique personal story, one that has captivated people everywhere, especially young people," Rice told *WR News.*

The daughter of Chinese **immigrants,** California-born Kwan won her first world figure-skating title when she was 15. (An immigrant is a person who comes from another country to live in a new country permanently.) In total, Kwan has won 43 championships, including an Olympic silver medal in 1998 and a bronze medal in 2002.

"I am honored to accept this appointment and to serve my country," Kwan says. "As an athlete, I have always been proud to represent the United States around the world. Being able to do so in this new position is very special and meaningful to me."

[1] **abroad:** away from one's home; in foreign countries

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